before this body. It is time we decided what direction the party and the country will take from this point onwards.'

Was this offer of resignation spontaneous, or was it part of an orchestrated strategy to force the party to support him in its hour of crisis? The top BJP leadership had been divided on the issue while the RSS had put its weight behind Modi. L.K. Advani was clear—if Modi resigned, the party could not face the electorate in Gujarat. 'The "pseudo-secularists" may not approve, but Modi has emerged as the defender of "Hindu interests" in the aftermath of Godhra—he is a hero for our cadres,' was the gist of Advani's argument. Vajpayee was equally clear—Modi's failure to control the riots was a blot on the ruling coalition at the Centre, the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) and would only lead to its break-up. In the end, the Advani logic won out—the national executive rejected Modi's offer to resign. The party had re-emphasized its faith in its core Hindutva ideology—the ideology that unites and galvanizes its cadres, the voter-mobilizing machine, far more effectively than any other plank.

Years later, I sat over a drink at the India International Centre bar with Brajesh Mishra, Vajpayee's all-powerful principal secretary, to find out why the former prime minister fell in line so easily. 'Make no mistake, Vajpayee wanted Modi to resign. But while he may have been in charge of the government, the party did not belong to him. The BJP is not the Congress. If the party and the RSS come together even a prime minister like Vajpayee cannot have his way,' said Mishra, a trifle wistfully. In a television interview after his surprise defeat in the 2004 general elections, Vajpayee admitted that not removing Modi at the time was a mistake. I see it slightly differently. I believe that in the madness of the summer of 2002, Vajpayee could not have afforded to force Modi to resign. Godhra and the riots which followed had transformed Modi into a Hindu Hriday Samrat—he now represented the soul of the brotherhood in saffron. Through the trauma of the riots, a new leader had been born. Vajpayee, by contrast, was simply the acceptable public face of a coalition government.

The decision to reject Modi's offer of resignation electrified the Goa gathering. Cries of 'Modi Zindabad', '*Desh ka neta kaisa ho, Narendra*